

**The Symbiotic Relationship of Branding and Sponsorship Activation:
Leveraging Instagram for Effective Sports Marketing in Indian Football**

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STATEMENT OF ORIGINALITY

I, Kaushal Subramaniam Manjeri Ramakrishnan, hereby declare that this dissertation and the research on which it has been based is my original work, except where otherwise stated. All quotations and other sources of information have been duly acknowledged. I also declare that this dissertation does not exceed the set word limit of 12,000.

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Dated: 10/10/2023

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Abstract

This research examined the symbiotic relationship between branding, sponsorship activation, and social media platforms like Instagram for sports marketing and athlete endorsements in Indian football. The study used a mixed-methods approach to combine qualitative interviews and quantitative social media analysis. Semi-structured interviews with athletes, athlete representatives and a brand representative provided nuanced insights into stakeholders' strategies, challenges and perceptions regarding leveraging Instagram. Key themes that emerged highlighted the role of consistent, authentic content in building athlete brand image, alignment of values as core sponsorship selection criteria, emphasis on creative storytelling and seamless messaging in campaigns, and opportunities like personalised engagement despite limitations in evaluating effectiveness.

Quantitative content analysis of leading Indian footballers' Instagram posts revealed higher engagement for sponsorships, allowing audience connections and indicating the need for relevant partnerships. Overall, positive sentiment reflected brand endorsements aligning with fan support.

Findings demonstrate social media's potential for athlete branding in India through strategic alignment, authenticity and partnership agility. However, generalisability constraints due to sample size and data availability are acknowledged. The research provides a foundation for further inquiry to optimise sports marketing in virtual spaces where consumer engagement is rapidly evolving. By establishing connections between athletes, brands and audiences, these insights can guide stakeholders in leveraging social media presence and synergies for effective collaborations and strong brand building through consistent innovation.

Introduction

Background and Context

Sport marketing bridges the gap between sports fans and the multifaceted branding and sponsorship activation world. Through various media channels, this dynamic field addresses the diverse needs of sport customers, including participants, spectators, consumers of sport-related products, and avid sports fans (Smith and Stewart, 2015). Unlike traditional marketing, sport marketing has a unique influence by indirectly promoting non-sport goods and services (Hoye et al., 2015). Within this context, sponsorship has evolved dramatically.

Its marketing strategy has evolved from philanthropic and passive to a strategic driver of corporate development, seamlessly integrated into the promotional mix and expanding its footprint in global marketing budgets (Seguin, 2007). This transformation is embodied in the concept of ‘activation,’ which is frequently used interchangeably with the terms ‘leveraging’ and ‘servicing.’ Activation refers to the additional investments and efforts made as part of a sponsorship that goes beyond the rights fees paid to acquire a property (O’Reilly and Horning, 2013). This study aims to learn the nuanced strategies that underpin successful athlete endorsements and how social media (Instagram) has played a role in that, in the Indian footballing context.

The growing importance of online and digital marketing in sponsorship activations is essential to this changing landscape (Meenaghan et al., 2013). Notably, social media platforms have emerged as critical tools in many organisations’ sponsorship activation arsenals (Chanavat and Desbordes, 2014). This shift toward digital engagement was exemplified by sponsors allocating 15-20% of their sponsorship budgets to digital marketing efforts during the London 2012 Olympics (Gillooly et al., 2017), offering a compelling case study in the utilisation of social media for sponsorship activation (Meenaghan et al., 2013).

However, it is worth noting that the literature on sponsors’ utilisation of social media within the realm of sponsorship activation remains relatively uncharted territory (Geurin and Gee, 2014; Abeza et al., 2015). Previous studies have primarily focused on whether sponsors post about their sponsorships on social media (Abeza et al., 2014). Additionally, some research has delved into the intricate process of evaluating a sponsorship’s efficacy through social media metrics (Delia and Armstrong, 2015), while others have explored the impact of communicating sponsorships via social media on critical factors such as perceived congruity and relationship quality (Do et al., 2015).

Research Problem and Rationale

In the dynamic world of sports marketing, the symbiotic relationship between branding and sponsorship activation is at the heart of the research topic, which focuses on the use of social media platforms, specifically Instagram and Indian football, in this study. Given its growing importance for brands and players, a better understanding of how to use Instagram for brand endorsements and sponsorship activations in the sports business is required, that is, the steps taken by brand representatives in collaboration with athletes and athlete representatives to

ensure a successful social media campaign of the sponsorship collaboration in Indian football. However, the lack of thorough research in this area leaves a knowledge gap regarding the approaches and difficulties associated with this intersection (Abeza et al., 2014; Geurin and Gee, 2014; Abeza et al., 2015). The revolutionary impact of social media on sports marketing methods (Mohammadkazemi, 2015) also serves as the foundation for this research. Marketers use social media as a powerful tool to increase brand recognition and customer engagement while simultaneously attempting to associate themselves with athletes who appeal to their target market (Latif et al., 2014). Furthermore, athletes can also become influential brand ambassadors, directly connecting with their followers and increasing the marketing value of endorsements (Mogaji et al., 2020).

This research aims to push the field of sports marketing by exploring the aspects of branding and sponsorship activation on Instagram by uncovering the strategies that Indian football athletes, athlete agents and brand representatives employ to achieve brand endorsements and sponsorships in today's era. Moreover, understanding the challenges involved in evaluating the effectiveness of these efforts can contribute to developing sports marketing plans in the future. This study is motivated by its potential to enhance the efficiency of sports marketing initiatives to benefit athletes, sports organisations and brands. Additionally, it serves as a resource for academics, practitioners and stakeholders in leveraging social media platforms, especially Instagram, for effective brand promotion and endorsements within the realm of sports marketing.

Aim and Objectives

Focusing on utilising Instagram, this study examines the symbiotic relationship between branding and sponsorship activation in sports marketing and the strategic use of Instagram by athletes, athlete representatives, and brand representatives in the Indian footballing industry to improve brand endorsements and sponsorship activations.

Objectives:

1. Examine the impact of branding and social media sponsorship on football athletes' personal brand image and marketability in the Indian context.

2. Critically assess the criteria employed by athlete representatives in selecting brand partnerships that align with the footballing athletes' values and personal brand identity in India.
3. Analyse the creation of authentic and engaging social media campaigns by brand representatives, ensuring consistency with the brand's messaging.
4. Identify challenges and opportunities in measuring the effectiveness of branding and sponsorship campaigns on social media platforms for all stakeholders.

Scope of the Dissertation

This study investigates the symbiotic relationship between branding and sponsorship activation in the context of sports marketing, explicitly emphasising leveraging Instagram for effective marketing strategies within Indian football. The primary stakeholders involved in this study include Indian football players, athlete representatives, and brand representatives engaged in sponsorship activations and brand endorsements. The research will employ qualitative methods, primarily in-depth interviews with the identified stakeholders, to gain comprehensive insights into their strategies, challenges, and perceptions regarding branding and sponsorship activation through social media, especially Instagram. Additionally, the study will analyse relevant data from social media posts to triangulate and bolster the interview findings, enhancing the credibility of the results.

The scope of this research aims to enhance the understanding of how branding, sponsorship activation, and social media synergise in sports marketing, offering practical takeaways for brands, athletes, and athlete representatives to enhance their marketing campaigns. The study intends to provide valuable insights into the dynamic field of sports marketing, particularly on Instagram, by focusing on the unique Indian football context.

Despite this study's contributions, some limitations need to be acknowledged. These limitations can be found in the methodology section of this study. By acknowledging these limitations and maintaining an approach, the goal is to contribute to understanding branding and sponsorship activation, specifically within the Indian football context, on Instagram.

Structure of the Dissertation

To enable a thorough investigation of the symbiotic link between branding, sponsorship activation, and Instagram in sports marketing in the Indian footballing context, the dissertation will be divided into multiple cohesive sections. Following the introduction, a critical analysis of prior research on sports marketing, branding, sponsorship activation, and social media will be presented, highlighting gaps and theoretical underpinnings. The methodology section will describe the qualitative approach, along with social media data analysis and interviews with Indian football athletes, athlete representatives, and brand representatives. The following data presentation and analysis will highlight the conclusions drawn from these sources. The dissertation will conclude with a section on significant findings, applications, and potential directions for further investigation, including recommendations. This organised framework will offer a solid foundation for an in-depth analysis of the study issue.

Literature Review

Bearing in mind the objectives of this study, i.e., to learn the nuanced strategies that underpin successful athlete endorsements and how social media (Instagram) has played a role in that, in the Indian footballing context, the literature review will delve into topics that will cover the bases that form the foundation of this aim.

Sport Marketing and Branding

According to Chalip (2006), sport marketing has developed into a distinct academic field and should be studied separately from conventional marketing. It is crucial that academics studying sport management keep looking into novel marketing strategies (Scola and Gordon, 2019). Jankovic and Jaksic-Stojanovic (2019) state that from many different perspectives, sport today plays a much more complex and significant role than it did in the past. Also, according to (Gratton and Henry, 2016), sport has evolved from simply being a way of life that provides positive energy and promotes health to a symbol of national power and a type of business sector with significant effects on various facets of social development. Additionally, modern sports organisations know how lucrative their industry is and spend a lot of money on branding and marketing, and it is obvious why developing a brand identity and image is

crucial for sports organisations, customers, fans, sports clubs, the media, and the nation at large when one considers that a brand is a synonym for quality and that it motivates, runs, empowers, and instils confidence (Jankovic and Jaksic-Stojanovic, 2019). According to Jankovic and Jaksic-Stojanovic (2019), a sports brand as a holistic sum of many different elements represents a unique and identifiable symbol of a sports organisation, which makes it different from its competitors, and the value of the sports brand is strongly used in the service of increasing the revenue of the sports organisation.

While on-field success still matters, professional sports organisations must leverage their brand equity to adapt to the ever-expanding entertainment industry (Rein, 2015). Brand equity is the commercial value that derives from consumer perception of the brand name of a particular product or service rather than from the product itself, and brand equity exists when consumers are familiar with the brand and perceive some positive associations (such as thoughts and ideas) towards that brand (Aaker, 1991; Keller, 1993). The brand encourages consumer or customer loyalty, which can increase willingness to pay for a good or service by 20 to 25% (Kotler and Keller, 2016). Once marketing managers successfully build strong brand equity, consumers are more likely to develop brand loyalty and regularly use that brand. Therefore, sports marketers should raise brand awareness, improve brand equity, and cultivate a sizable, devoted client base (Brunello, 2018).

Pertaining to this study and its objectives, solid and novel branding and marketing strategies are essential for a football player or a brand that wishes to associate with a particular football player because these factors contribute to building brand equity. With good brand equity, the target audience of the parties involved will also instil brand loyalty, which, as stated previously, can increase the willingness of the audience to pay for a good or a service, i.e., in this case, the product or service of a brand that a football athlete will be promoting.

Sponsorship Activation Strategies Using Social Media in Sport Marketing

Social media marketing took effect in 2006 when Facebook widened its network and introduced Facebook Ads in December of that year, and Facebook became the torchbearer for social media marketing (Alicia, 2022; Dou, 2023). As mentioned earlier, solid and novel branding and marketing strategies help brands and athletes build a personal brand image and, in turn, brand loyalty.

Athletes can be considered celebrities (Joaquin, 2021), and sports marketers primarily operate on the assumption that athletes can improve the perception of their product, even if most admit that the impact of utilising athletes as endorsers cannot be easily assessed in terms of revenues or sales (O'Neal et al., 1987). However, celebrity advertising for businesses has now become a trend and a perceived winning formula for corporate image building and product marketing (Mukherjee, 2009); in this case, the betterment in the perception or sale of a product that a football athlete associates themselves with. In fact, a celebrity endorser's seal of approval can increase a brand's equity and forge an emotional connection with consumers if the athlete and the product are a good fit (Renton, 2009). Nevertheless, simply acquiring the sponsorship rights to a property does not ensure a return on investment, and activating the sponsorship is necessary for it to contribute to highly desired KPIs like brand awareness and recall (Jacobs et al., 2014). Because sponsorship activation creates interaction between the event, the sponsoring brand, potential attendees, and attendees (Conlon, 2016), or in this case, the social media campaign, the brand involved, and the target audience.

Sponsor ambitions have changed over time from primarily seeking brand exposure and promoting brand awareness and association to a position where sophisticated sponsors increasingly use sponsorship to promote brand engagement, either as a platform for delivering experiential marketing opportunities or as a channel to connect with consumer passions (Meenaghan, 2013). Weeks et al. (2008) define sponsorship activation as 'communications that promote the sponsorship audience's engagement, involvement, or participation with the sponsor.' As a result, activation supports the idea that fans no longer choose to consume advertising content passively and instead desire to interact actively and experience sponsor brands (Dees, 2011). In this scenario, social media is increasingly used for sponsorship activation (Chanavat and Desbordes, 2014).

Sponsors can achieve various goals through social media activation in an increasingly crowded and cluttered sponsorship environment (Degaris et al., 2009), including brand awareness, fan engagement, information sharing, conducting sales promotions, building relationships (Dees, 2011), and influencing consumer attitudes toward brands (Schivinski and Dabrowski, 2016). In the context of sports, social media can help with fan connection in the sporting environment (Pegoraro, 2010), allowing for a more humane approach to communication and, as a result, a greater acceptance of its function as a marketing tool among those fans (Thompson et al., 2014). New media marketing requires more than just

utilising cutting-edge technology to be successful; it must also adapt to the evolving demands and lifestyles of sports customers (Smith and Stewart, 2015). Social media gives organisations a direct connection with customers, allowing them to project a particular brand image and create strong brand associations (Anagnostopoulos et al., 2018). Therefore, social media can be critical in forming proper perceptions and attitudes in the minds of consumers, which is essential for creating a great brand (Keller, 2009).

Sports teams were early users of social media platforms (Hambrick and Kang, 2015; Hambrick et al., 2010; Paragnas and Anagnostopolous, 2015), using them not only to keep in touch with and foster two-way contact with their supporters but also to learn more about their preferences and habits (Browning and Sanderson, 2012), raise brand awareness (Eagleman, 2013), and promote and attract sponsors (Eagleman and Krohn, 2012). Furthermore, the increasing popularity of these platforms represents an opportunity for sport teams to communicate with their current fan base and to expand it (Clavio and Walsh, 2013). On the contrary, sports consumers increasingly seek pertinent content from online sources due to their interest in and engagement with the sport product. They have also come to expect their favourite team to communicate and engage with them directly through social media platforms (Ballouli and Hutchinson, 2010; Broughton, 2012). Due to the intrinsic qualities of social media, supporters are not restricted by geographic boundaries and may follow the activities of their favourite team from anywhere (Gibbons and Dixon, 2010).

Instagram is a platform that uses images as its primary mode of communication within the social media context and is rapidly gaining traction among athletes and sporting organisations worldwide (Graham, 2013). Instagram has over 700 million active users, more than twice as many as Twitter, making it the finest platform for marketers since its introduction in October 2010 (Constine, 2017). Instagram is a particularly useful tool for sports teams because of its popularity and capacity for sharing multimedia content (Anagnostopoulos et al., 2018). As part of the broader social media family, Instagram can positively impact the affiliation of fans towards their team (Popp and Woratschek, 2016) and the team's revenues (Broughton, 2012).

Athlete Endorsements and Personal Branding

Given that the focus of this study revolves around sponsorship activation on social media, i.e., Instagram, by Indian footballing athletes, athlete endorsements are a significant part of sponsorship activation. With endorsements, one can regularly see athletes endorse or discuss

a particular brand or product, and this is a significant aspect of any collaboration or sponsorship since its fundamental nature lies in the partnership built between a brand and an athlete (Kane, 2021). Furthermore, this also translates into building a personal brand for the athlete. Even though endorsements are about the connection between an endorser and a brand, and advertising revolves around the relationship between the product and consumer (Butler, 2022), an activation campaign on social media intertwines these two concepts.

As explained before, athletes are celebrities, and celebrity endorsement has become a billion-dollar industry (Peetz et al., 2004). Worldwide, marketers view celebrity endorsement as a powerful marketing strategy (Spry et al., 2011). One-in-four adverts use celebrity endorsement (Priyankara et al., 2017). A positive attitude toward the endorsed brand has also been shown to result from celebrity endorsement (Till et al., 2008). According to Till (1998), celebrity brand ambassadors can increase brand equity by forging secondary connections. Seno and Lukas (2007) proposed that an endorsement by a celebrity acts as a co-brand for the endorsed product, building equity for both the product and the celebrity. Additionally, there is empirical evidence that a celebrity endorsement increases recall of both the advertised product and the celebrity (Atkin and Block, 1983). Using celebrities as brand ambassadors can also affect how unique and high-quality a product is viewed (Dean, 1999). However, little is known about how an endorser's credibility might affect the endorsed brand's equity. Furthermore, a brand's credibility is thought to help develop brand equity by indirectly enhancing the brand's appeal to consumers (Erdem and Swait, 1998).

Athletes' collaboration with brands is no longer confined to traditional advertising; it has seamlessly transitioned to the digital realm (Schneider et al., 2005). Brand endorsements now extend beyond mere product promotion to encompass an athlete's lifestyle, values, and persona (Erdogan, 1999). These collaborations showcase products and reflect the alignment between the athlete's personal image and the brand's identity (Dumont and Ots, 2020). In the digital age, social media platforms have redefined personal branding, providing athletes with direct channels to interact with their audience (Dašić et al., 2021). Athletes engage fans personally by selecting content representing these aspects, building a sense of connection beyond the playing field (Smith et al., 2017). Athlete endorsements are most effective when the partnership is genuine and the athlete's personal brand is strong (Sharifzadeh et al., 2021). Athletes who engage in meaningful connections and effectively communicate their brand identity develop a devoted fan base that perceives endorsements as trustworthy

recommendations rather than forced advertisements (Lin et al., 2021). In conclusion, the intricate linking of athlete endorsements and personal branding has led to a mutually beneficial connection between companies and athletes in the field of sports marketing.

Consumer Behaviour and Engagement

An athlete's personal brand cannot solely be built by taking up endorsement deals. The success of a collaboration between an athlete and a brand also depends on consumer behaviour, consumer engagement, return on investment, usage of emerging social media trends, and various other factors.

The relationship between athletes, companies, and their audiences has been redefined due to the convergence of athlete endorsements and social media (Goss et al., 2007). Consumer perceptions and preferences are significantly influenced by athlete endorsements (Jardim, 2021). Due to athletes' aspirational nature as role models, people tend to identify products they are endorsed with attributes that the athlete exemplifies, which helps to build a positive brand image (Arya et al., 2019). Due to this associative branding, consumers may see endorsed products as more desirable, trustworthy, and consistent with their identities (Emmadi, 2017).

Similarly, athlete endorsements' trustworthiness and reputation influence customer behaviour (Mansour and Diab, 2016). Additionally, it is crucial to remember that relationships within the sports brand ecosystem are dynamic as a result of things like changes in team performance, coaches who are fired and then hired by other teams, numerous athlete transfers, or the entry of new sponsors or investors. These elements can alter fans' social networks and show that businesses must continuously adapt to the shifting dynamics of the sports brand ecosystem and accompanying consumer feelings (Kunkel and Biscaia, 2020).

Social media channels provide athletes with a versatile canvas to engage their audience through captivating storytelling (Alexander, 2017). Consumers are more likely to feel emotionally connected to athletes when they hear honest stories about their journeys, difficulties, and how sponsored products fit into their lifestyles (Riitvis et al., 2015). Storytelling has a powerful emotional impact that increases engagement and builds community among followers. The interactive dynamic between athletes, brands, and consumers can be enhanced by athletes' engagement methods on social media (Brison and Geurin, 2021). Interactive engagement includes responding to comments, sharing

user-generated content, and hosting Q&A sessions. Athletes who frequently communicate with their fans foster inclusivity, strengthening brand loyalty and promoting continuous connections.

Consumer scepticism towards endorsements necessitates carefully balancing authenticity and commercial interests, and athletes who genuinely use and believe in the products they endorse mitigate potential scepticism (Gräve and Bartsch, 2021). Conversely, endorsements viewed as hollow or disassociated with an athlete's personal brand risk alienating fans and lowering engagement (O'Connell, 2022). In conclusion, the convergence of athlete endorsements and social media platforms sparked a shift in consumer behaviour and engagement (Keshkar et al., 2019).

Measurement Metrics and Effectiveness

Another way of determining consumer engagement and behaviour is through the usage of measurement metrics on social media, which will, in turn, help understand the effectiveness of a sponsorship collaboration. These can be factors such as follower growth, sentiment analysis of the comments section, and number of likes per post, among others. In the dynamic landscape of athlete endorsements and social media, assessing the effectiveness of such collaborations requires robust measurement metrics. Quantitative metrics provide a tangible assessment of endorsement impact (Miller and Cioffi, 2004). Likes, comments, shares, and click-through rates provide information on the immediate engagement of athlete-endorsed content (Perreault and Mosconi, 2018). These indicators reflect the response rate of the audience and the followers' receptivity to the endorsement.

Albeit uncommon, an athlete's follower count increasing after a brand deal indicates a broader audience (Bergstrom and Backman, 2013). Monitoring growth in followers after an endorsement reveals how much the partnership boosts an athlete's social media presence (Bredikhina et al., 2022). Thus, an increase in followers may signify greater brand exposure and engagement. Conversion metrics primarily determine the effectiveness of the endorsement's conversion (Hoffman and Fodor, 2010). Metrics like website views, discount code redemptions, and actual purchases following an athlete-endorsed article provide quantifiable proof of the influence of endorsement on consumer behaviour towards conversion (Powell et al., 2011).

Sentiment analysis examines qualitative factors to assess consumer sentiment and perceptions sparked by the endorsement (Pathak and Shelat, 2017). A thorough grasp of how consumers regard the partnership and the effect the brand has on their sentiments is made possible by mining comments, reviews, and mentions that follow an endorsement (Zhang et al., 2017). Effectiveness can also be gauged through the endorsement's impact on brand-specific metrics. Metrics like brand awareness, recall, and association can show how the endorsement affects customers' perceptions of the brand (Buil et al., 2013).

Determining the economic sustainability of athlete endorsements largely depends on ROI assessment (Tinaz, 2017). The ROI is calculated by comparing the revenue earned to the investment made. Brands can determine the financial benefits and strategic worth of collaboration by analysing the ROI (Van Buren, 1999). A longitudinal investigation of engagement metrics is necessary to determine the long-term effects of athlete endorsements (Vulturius et al., 2019). Insights about an endorsement's long-term impact can be gained by tracking consistent engagement, follower growth, and brand affinity (Karagür et al., 2021; Gross and von Wangenheim, 2022). Furthermore, endorsements often span multiple social media platforms. Effective assessment demands cross-platform analysis, wherein metrics are consolidated to gauge the holistic impact of the endorsement across diverse digital spaces. In conclusion, there are many different measuring measures and ways to assess the success of athlete endorsements on social media.

Emerging Trends and Innovations

Emerging trends on social media must be used as and when they are at their peak performance. Such techniques work well with the algorithms set by social media platforms and also garner as much traffic to a post as possible. Technological improvements and shifting consumer tastes drive the landscape of athlete endorsements and social media marketing (Filo et al., 2015). Immersive and interactive brand experiences are provided through virtual and augmented reality technologies. Athlete endorsements transcend simple posts by letting fans interact digitally with merchandise or watch branded videos, which increases consumer engagement and brand recognition (Leung et al., 2022).

The popularity of live streaming has also grown as a direct and genuine method for athletes to interact with their audience (Fatma, 2020). Brands utilise live sessions to provide in-person product demonstrations, Q&A sessions, and behind-the-scenes looks, building real

connections and raising the credibility of endorsements (Green, 2016; Smilansky, 2018). As creative ways to include fans and monetise athlete endorsements, Non-Fungible Tokens (NFTs) and digital collectables have also arisen (Trautman, 2022). In order to give fans ownership and a special connection to their favourite athletes, athletes can mine NFTs linked to premium content (Wansink, 2022). Socially conscious endorsements link athletes to issues they support and connect with audiences who share these values. Brands are working with athletes who support social and environmental causes more frequently, tying their corporate identities to important principles (Ramaswamy and Ozcan, 2016).

Artificial intelligence provides personalised content recommendations based on user choices and behaviours (Rathore, 2017). Content with athletes' endorsements can be customised to users' interests, increasing engagement and customer satisfaction (Liang et al., 2006). Gamified endorsements rely on challenges and contests to keep viewers interested (Sardi et al., 2017). In order to promote interactive involvement and community development, athletes invite fans to take part in challenges that are relevant to their sport or the products offered by the company (Buser et al., 2021). Digital twins and virtual athlete avatars expand the reach of endorsement opportunities (Saddik et al., 2021). In virtual reality and gaming environments, brands may work with virtual athletes to increase their exposure across various platforms (Cranmer et al., 2020). In conclusion, cutting-edge trends that use technology, interactive experiences, and authenticity to engage audiences in fresh ways characterise the changing landscape of athlete endorsements and social media marketing. The dynamics of endorsement strategies continue to change as brands and athletes adjust to these new trends, providing new opportunities for brand-consumer relationships in the digital age.

Methodology

Introduction

According to the work by Doyle et al. (2009), "*An overview of mixed methods research*," the said method tends to the need to comprehend the multifaceted dynamics of this study. The study employs a mixed-methods approach combining qualitative and quantitative techniques to understand the phenomenon comprehensively. The rationale for this approach is rooted in the complexities of athlete endorsements, which necessitate a comprehensive investigation. Qualitative interviews will elicit nuanced insights into the experiences, motivations, and

strategies of footballing athletes, athlete representatives, and brand representatives (Smith and Sparkes, 2016). These qualitative findings will be supplemented by a quantitative examination of athletes' social media posts, allowing for the examination of engagement metrics and sentiment. This will, in turn, help achieve the objectives of this study.

The following sections will cover each method's specifics, such as the interview process, data collection, ethical considerations, and data analysis procedures. Furthermore, this methodology encourages triangulation, which improves the study's validity and reliability (Bush, 2012; Bans-Akutey and Tiimub, 2021). The research will use a mixed-methods approach to uncover the intricate interplay between branding, sponsorship activation, and social media in the context of athlete endorsements.

Research Approach and Design

This study's research approach and design include both exploratory and explanatory elements. The study takes a mixed-methods approach, strategically combining qualitative and quantitative methodologies to provide a comprehensive view of the symbiotic relationship between athlete endorsements, branding, sponsorship activation, and social media (Ponce and Pagán-Maldonado, 2015), especially Instagram, in the Indian football context. In the exploratory phase of the research, qualitative interviews are used to capture the lived experiences and insights of football athletes, athlete representatives, and brand representatives. Semi-structured interviews allow participants to articulate their perspectives, strategies, challenges, and successes in athlete endorsements, allowing for in-depth exploration. This qualitative phase adheres to an interpretivist research philosophy, focusing on understanding the participants' subjective viewpoints and contexts (Blackwell, 2018).

The explanatory phase then quantitatively analyses athletes' social media posts on Instagram. This positivist-guided analysis seeks to extract measurable engagement metrics and sentiment analysis data. The quantitative data will be analysed statistically to identify patterns, correlations, and trends, providing a quantitative foundation for the qualitative findings, i.e., determining how Instagram, and what aspects of it, contribute to the success of a collaboration between a brand and a football athlete in India. This mixed-methods approach ensures methodological triangulation, which improves the study's robustness and validity (Caruth, 2013). The qualitative findings shed light on the stakeholders' motivations, strategies, and perceptions. In contrast, the quantitative findings provide empirical evidence

of the impact of branding and sponsorship activation on athletes' social media presence. Combining these approaches allows for a comprehensive understanding of the interaction between branding, sponsorship, and social media, enriching the study's findings and adding to the depth of analysis.

Sampling Strategy

According to Etikan et al. (2016), *convenience sampling* involves using respondents who are "convenient" to the researcher. There is no pattern in gathering these respondents; they could be recruited simply by asking people in the street, public buildings, or workplaces. Also, according to the same study, *purposive sampling* is a form of non-probability sampling in which researchers rely on their judgement when choosing population members to participate in their surveys.

This study's sampling strategies are purposive and convenience sampling, which allows the researcher to capture diverse perspectives from footballing athletes, athlete representatives, and brand representatives (Petty et al., 2012). Given the study's niche focus, a non-probability sampling approach is appropriate for obtaining participants with relevant experiences in athlete endorsements and social media. A purposive sampling technique will be used to select football athletes participating in various branding and sponsorship partnerships. This ensures a wide range of perspectives from various sporting backgrounds and endorsement scenarios. Athlete and brand representatives will be chosen through professional networks, leveraging existing connections made through previous collaborations. All the participants will be provided with a consent form recording their consent to participate in this study and an information sheet informing them of the purpose of this study and why they have been approached to participate.

Due to the limited access to personnel directly connected to this study's fields, the sampling will primarily focus on Indian athletes, representatives, and brands. The same rationale will also determine the interview sample size while attempting to address all of this study's objectives. The sampling strategy is consistent with the qualitative focus of the study, emphasising rich insights and in-depth narratives (Elliott, 2005, p. 18). Although convenience sampling has inherent limitations in terms of generalisability (Winton and Sabol, 2021), the study's goal is to uncover intricate dynamics in the symbiotic relationship between branding,

sponsorship activation, and social media (especially Instagram) in the context of athlete endorsements in Indian football, rather than to provide universal findings.

Data Collection and Analysis

Data Collection:

This study takes a mixed-methods approach, combining qualitative and quantitative data collection techniques. Semi-structured interviews will be conducted with football players, athlete representatives, and brand representatives, eliciting in-depth insights into the participants' experiences, strategies, and perceptions of athlete endorsements and social media. In addition to interviews, quantitative data will be gathered by examining Instagram posts by Indian football athletes participating in the study. The study will specifically look at posts about brand endorsements and sponsorships. This quantitative study will reveal athlete-brand collaborations' frequency, engagement, and impact on social media platforms.

Data Analysis:

Thematic analysis will be used to analyse the qualitative data from interviews. Coding the interview transcripts, identifying recurring themes, and categorising data into meaningful patterns will all be part of the thematic analysis process, which will be done using Google Docs. This method will allow for a more in-depth examination of the factors that influence athlete endorsements, the role of social media in brand activation, and the overall impact on personal branding while also trying to answer the objectives of this study. Quantitative techniques like *content analysis and engagement metrics* will be used to analyse Instagram data. Instagram posts will be classified based on the brand endorsement type, the engagement level (likes, comments, and shares), and the sentiment expressed. This study will provide quantitative information about the effectiveness of brand collaborations on social media platforms.

Integration of Qualitative and Quantitative Data:

The research will combine qualitative and quantitative findings to provide a complete picture of the symbiotic relationship between branding, sponsorship activation, and social media in sports marketing. Qualitative insights will help explain athletes' and brands' motivations and strategies, while quantitative data will provide measurable indicators of social media impact.

Overall, this mixed-methods approach ensures a comprehensive examination of the research questions by combining the breadth of quantitative data with the depth of qualitative narratives, resulting in a robust analysis of the subject matter.

Ethical Considerations

Because of the involvement of human participants and the analysis of social media data, this study strongly emphasises ethical considerations. The vital ethical principles guiding this study are:

Informed Consent: All participants, including footballing athletes, athlete representatives, and brand representatives, will be given a detailed information sheet outlining the study's purpose, procedures, and potential risks and benefits before conducting interviews. They must provide informed written consent indicating their willingness to participate. Participants will be informed that they can withdraw from the study till the 25th of September.

Anonymity and Confidentiality: During the analysis phase, all personal information and identifiers will be removed from interview transcripts and social media data to protect participants' privacy. Participants' names and affiliations will be replaced with pseudonyms to ensure anonymity. Data gathered from social media platforms will be securely stored, and any direct quotes used in the dissertation will be anonymised to avoid identification.

Data Security: Data from social media will be collected and stored using safe and approved tools and methods. All data, including transcripts, will be saved on a password-protected computer that only the researcher can access. To maintain confidentiality, once the dissertation has been graded and completed, all data collected during the study, both qualitative and quantitative, will be permanently deleted.

Minimisation of Harm: When discussing personal experiences and perceptions, the researcher acknowledges the potential emotional impact on participants. Care will be taken during interviews to create a supportive and non-judgmental environment. Participants will also be encouraged to avoid questions or topics with which they are unfamiliar.

Third-Party Involvement: Participants for this study were approached by individuals with whom the researcher has prior professional relationships. They were informed about the

study and the researcher's intention to interview them beforehand. This reduces the role of third parties or gatekeepers in the hiring process.

Compliance: This study follows all applicable data protection and ethical guidelines, including those established by the researcher's academic institution. Any necessary permissions or approvals will be obtained to ensure compliance with ethical standards. These ethical considerations are critical to preserving the research's integrity and credibility and ensuring the well-being and rights of all participants.

Validity and Reliability

Internal Validity: A rigorous approach will be used throughout the data collection and analysis process to ensure the internal validity of this research. A well-established qualitative research method, thematic analysis, will be used to identify recurring themes and patterns in the interview data.

External Validity: The study's findings will be carefully contextualised in the contexts of sports marketing, branding, and social media. To increase external validity, the study will include a diverse group of participants, such as football players, athlete representatives, and brand representatives, who can offer a variety of perspectives on the symbiotic relationship between branding, sponsorship activation, and social media.

Reliability: Maintaining consistency in research procedures will ensure reliability. Interviews will be conducted in a semi-structured format with predefined questions to ensure consistency in data collection.

Triangulation: This study will use methodological triangulation to improve the reliability of its findings by combining qualitative (interviews) and quantitative (social media data analysis) approaches. Combining these methods allows for a more in-depth understanding of the research topic and increases the study's overall reliability.

Peer Review: The study will also be peer-reviewed by academic advisors. Their feedback and critical evaluation will help to improve the study's overall validity and reliability. This research aims to uphold the validity and reliability of its findings by incorporating these strategies, providing a solid foundation for understanding the symbiotic relationship of branding and sponsorship activation within the context of social media in sports marketing.

Limitations

Sample Size: This study's relatively small sample size may limit the generalisability of findings to a larger population of athletes, athlete representatives, and brand representatives. The study intends to interview a minimum of five participants, which, while valuable, may only represent part of the full range of experiences and perspectives within the sports marketing industry.

Geographical Focus: Another limitation is the geographical focus on India, which may limit the findings' global applicability. The dynamics and experiences of branding, sponsorship activation, and social media engagement in sports marketing may differ significantly across regions and cultures.

Participant Accessibility: One potential challenge is recruiting participants and brand representatives who may be unwilling to participate. While the study will strive to engage a range of stakeholders, it is essential to acknowledge that limitations in selection could affect the breadth of insights gained from this study.

Self-Selection Bias: Participants may be biased because of self-selection. Those who agree to participate may have different experiences or perspectives than those who decline to participate. This bias may have an impact on the study's findings' representativeness.

Social Media Data: While social media data analysis is valuable, it may have limitations due to the availability and accuracy of publicly available data. Changes in social media algorithms or privacy settings could impact data collection and analysis.

Reliance on Self-Reported Data: It is worth mentioning that this study relies on data obtained through interviews where participants report their experiences. Although steps will be taken to minimise bias through interview design and data analysis, bias or inaccuracies are still possible.

Temporal Factors: Considering the constantly evolving social media platforms and marketing trends, the effectiveness of branding and sponsorship activation campaigns might change over time. This study provides a snapshot at a point in time. However, because social media platforms and marketing trends change quickly, findings from this study may become outdated.

Language and Communication Barriers: Because the study will be in English, some potential participants may face language barriers. This constraint may have an impact on the sample's diversity.

Ethical Considerations: Ethical considerations may limit the information participants are willing to share, especially regarding specific brand collaborations or strategies.

While these limitations are recognised, they are mitigated through careful research design, transparency, and dedication to data collection and analysis rigour. While recognising these inherent constraints, the study aims to provide valuable insights into the symbiotic relationship of branding and sponsorship activation with social media in sports marketing.

Discussion and Results

Introduction

This chapter will thematically analyse the data collected through the interviews. Eight people were approached, out of which five interviews went through successfully: two athletes, two athlete representatives, and a brand representative. The thematic analysis will also be clubbed with content analysis to analyse the social media data, which will conjointly help reach the study's objectives and identify limitations within this study and the results of the study, highlighting numerous areas for further research.

The core focus of this research is to understand how Indian footballing athletes and the brands they associate or collaborate with leverage social media platforms, especially Instagram in this case, to solidify their presence among their audience, viz., the brand image. The athletes interviewed for this study have experience playing in the top-tier footballing league in India, the Indian Super League, and also in the second-tier league, the I-League. The athlete representatives are also from highly reputable agencies, managing one of India's best sets of athletes. The brand representative who was interviewed was also from one of the most reputable Indian sports supplement brands, who, unlike the other interviewees, opted to stay anonymous.

Particulars:

ID - current Inter Kashi player, ex-Hyderabad FC player

AA - current NorthEast United FC player, ex-Mohammedan SC player

AG - athlete representative of the agency FairPlay Sports

HM - athlete representative of the agency Four Flags (sister branch of FairPlay Sports)

ABR - brand representative of the Indian sports supplement brand Fast&Up

Thematic Analysis

Theme 1: Consistent and engaging Instagram content translating to Personal Brand

A consistent theme across the posts on Instagram, utilising all the trending engagement tactics, and a consistent effort to tell a story through the posts to help build the athlete's personal brand has been talked about by almost every other interviewer.

ID emphasises that providing good and consistent content to keep the audience engaged and make the audience feel connected gives them something to look forward to in the future as well. This theme underscores the importance of consistent and engaging content to build a loyal following on social media. **ID** states, *"Consistency is key. I try to post regularly and provide content that my audience finds interesting. It is important to keep them engaged and make them look forward to what is coming next."* **ID** also emphasises the importance of utilising social media to inspire others and make a positive impact. He believes everyone has talent and should make the most of the platform to reach and inspire people. This highlights the potential of social media as a tool for influence and inspiration. **ID** states, *"Social media is a powerful tool. It allows us to reach a wide audience and inspire others. I believe that everyone has talent, and we should use social media to showcase our talents and inspire others to pursue their dreams."*

Similarly, **AA** also emphasises and acknowledges the importance of his Instagram profile not becoming a channel for the brand but rather one for himself to build a personal brand. He recognises the importance of focusing on football, training, matches, and messages to fans during the season. This highlights the strategic use of social media to create a positive brand image and engage with fans. **AA** states, *"I try to keep my Instagram focused on football-related content, whether it is training videos, match highlights, or messages to my fans. I want to create a positive brand image and show my dedication to the sport."*

AG also talked about the same concept but in a different way. He emphasised the impact of social media on sports marketing and how social media has transformed the landscape of

sports marketing by lowering the barrier to entry for many athletes. He explained that brands with smaller budgets can still engage in shorter-term associations through platforms like Instagram and Twitter. This will, in turn, allow the athletes to gradually and steadily build a personal brand image. He states, *“Social media has opened up new opportunities for athletes and brands to collaborate, even if they do not have the same level of fame or budget.”* This highlights the democratising effect of social media in allowing athletes to leverage their fame and engage in brand deals.

Addressing the first objective, i.e., to analyse the effects of social media sponsorship and branding on football athletes’ marketability and personal brand image in India, a recurring theme is revealed among the people interviewed. They stress the significance of **strategically utilising social media to establish and uphold their individual brand**. They put their efforts into producing regular, compelling content to keep their audience interested and motivated. For instance, **ID** emphasises the need for consistent, engaging content to develop a fan base and the use of social media as a tool for goodwill. Similarly, **AA** maintains a personable style on Instagram focused on football-related content and shows a love for the game. **AG** continues by saying that social media has democratised sports marketing and gradually allowed athletes with limited resources to develop their personal brands. These findings highlight the social media’s transformative influence on Indian athletes’ brand perception and marketability.

Theme 2: Selection criteria involved in collaborations, focusing on alignment of core values

The selection of brands by athletes or vice-versa largely depends on many factors. Among others, one of the main factors determining whether the collaboration will occur is the alignment of values between the athlete and the brand.

ID emphasises the importance of this in two scenarios. He highlights the need to strike a balance between promoting brand partnerships and engaging the audience with authentic content. He mentions that while he collaborates with brands, his Instagram profile primarily focuses on football, the athletic lifestyle, and a few brand collaborations. This, in turn, translates into maintaining authenticity while leveraging social media for brand promotion. **ID** states, *“I want to keep my personal life low-key on social media. I only expose a limited amount of my personal life to my audience. It is important to strike a balance between promoting brand partnerships and sharing authentic content.”*

Furthermore, speaking of authenticity, **ID** mentions that the story behind brand collaborations and the journey of hard work and dedication resonate with the audience and create a significant impact. That is, the power of storytelling in brand collaborations and the potential to connect with the audience on a deeper level is also paramount. **ID** states, *“The story behind brand collaborations is important. It is not just about promoting a product; it is about sharing the journey and the hard work that goes into achieving success. That is what resonates with the audience and creates a lasting impact.”*

According to **ID**, factors such as authenticity and storytelling emphasise the need for alignment between an athlete’s personal brand identity and the brands they partner with. The criteria would match core values, brand messaging, and target audiences and ensure partnerships reflect the athlete’s journey and persona.

On the other hand, while not opining on what he considers before collaborating with a brand, **AA** speculates on factors such as social media growth, followers, and engagement rates that brands consider when collaborating with an athlete. He mentions that collaborating with brands has become more prominent recently as brands use social media to advertise their products. He speculates on the factors that brands may consider when selecting athletes for promotions, such as the growth of their social media accounts, number of followers, engagement rate, and frequency of activity. This suggests that social media presence and engagement are crucial for athletes to attract brand collaborations and enhance their personal brand. **AA** explains, *“Brands are looking for athletes with a strong social media presence and high engagement rates. They want to partner with athletes who can reach a large audience and generate interest in their products.”*

Aligning with that, **ABR** states that one of the key factors the organisation considers while collaborating with athletes is the alignment of values, target audience, performance, and media presence. The organisation ensures a seamless connection between the athlete and the brand, which helps create a strong brand identity and resonate with the target audience. **ABR** said, *“We focus on aligning values, target audience, performance, and media presence.”*

From an athlete representative’s perspective, their focus shifts to factors such as the athlete’s benefits and the brand’s reputation, among others. **AG** explains that athletes have different requirements and preferences regarding brand collaborations. The agency conducts basic research on the brand to ensure its legitimacy and alignment with the athlete’s values. They

also consider factors such as the brand's background, legality, and controversy surrounding it. This highlights the importance of brand reputation and the need for careful consideration before collaborating. **AG** also clarifies that the agency's role is not to make decisions on behalf of the athlete but to present them with various brand options and provide information and advice. The agency informs the athlete about any negative coverage or controversies surrounding a brand and allows them to make an informed decision. This emphasises the agency's responsibility to guide and support athletes in making choices that align with their interests and values.

Furthermore, **AG** discusses the importance of preempting conflicts between athletes' personal brand image and the branding objectives of sponsors in social media campaigns. He emphasises the need to align the brand's and athlete's values and ethos before collaborating. This suggests that careful consideration and communication are necessary to ensure a successful partnership that aligns with both parties' objectives.

Similarly, **HM** emphasises that the terms athletes seek are crucial in facilitating successful collaborations. He states, *"Because if the athlete is unhappy with the collaboration... the whole deal becomes pointless."* Athletes' satisfaction with the products and deliverables is also highlighted in the example of the successful campaign with Myprotein, where 13 athletes collaborated and were happy with the products and deliverables. This underscores the significance of aligning the collaboration terms with the athletes' values and personal brand image to ensure their satisfaction and success.

Addressing the second objective of this study, i.e., a critical evaluation of the standards used by athlete representatives in India when choosing brand alliances that support football players' values and personal brand identities, a common theme that emerges is the importance of **alignment**. The overarching theme is the necessity for all components of a brand partnership to effectively align, whether it be an athlete's personal brand with partnered brands, an athlete's social media presence with brand collaboration criteria, or ensuring alignment between an athlete's values and a brand's reputation. In order to build successful and meaningful partnerships that align with the athlete's values and unique brand identity and ultimately benefit both the athlete and the partnered brand, this alignment is essential.

Theme 3: Authenticity and Consistency on Instagram

Maintaining authenticity is a significant aspect of brand and athlete collaboration. **ID** emphasises the need to be mindful of the content posted on social media and avoid promoting harmful or negative influences. He suggests being creative, engaging the audience, and focusing on the work and effort put in rather than flashy lifestyles. This highlights the importance of responsible content creation and using social media as a platform for positive messaging. **ID** states, *“We have a responsibility to create content that is positive and inspiring. It is not about showing off flashy lifestyles but about showcasing the hard work and effort that goes into achieving our goals.”*

AG mentions that anything that goes out on social media has to be approved by both the athlete and the agency. This highlights the importance of controlling shared content and ensuring it aligns with the athlete’s image and values. The involvement of both parties in the approval process emphasises the collaborative nature of these partnerships and the need for mutual agreement.

On the other hand, **ABR** shared an example of a successful brand endorsement campaign wherein Fast&Up partnered with Mayank Agarwal to share his fitness journey, highlighting their sports nutrition products as integral to his training routine. They also collaborated with Mumbai City FC and Bengaluru FC to showcase their products as part of the players’ performance optimisation strategies. The authenticity of the endorsements, captivating visual storytelling, and strategic timing of posts during critical matches resulted in heightened audience engagement and extended brand reach. He said, *“We achieved substantial engagement and brand exposure by aligning our products with the athletes’ genuine experiences and integrating them seamlessly into their social media content.”*

ABR also opines that Fast&Up co-creates engaging content with athletes that highlights the benefits of their brand while fitting seamlessly into the athlete’s social media presence. They constantly monitor emerging social media trends and platforms, adapt content formats to suit each trend and optimise for platform-specific engagement. This approach maximises the reach and impact of brand endorsements, resonating with the athlete’s followers and broader online audiences. He said, *“We strategically collaborate with athletes by co-creating engaging content that highlights our brand’s benefits while fitting seamlessly into their social media presence.”*

Addressing the third objective, i.e., to evaluate the development of genuine and interesting social media campaigns by brand representatives, ensuring that the brand's messaging is consistent, a common theme that emerges from the interviews conducted is the **emphasis on authenticity** in social media campaigns by brand representatives. Both **ID** and **ABR** emphasise the importance of producing authentic content that aligns with the athlete's values and experiences. This includes staying away from overly showy displays and putting more emphasis on showcasing effort and commitment. Additionally, the collaborative nature of content creation, wherein agencies and athletes participate in the approval process, emphasises the dedication to upholding authenticity. Authentic storytelling and content that seamlessly mesh with an athlete's social media presence can increase audience engagement and broaden brand reach, as illustrated by a successful example provided by **ABR**. In general, consistency and engaging social media campaigns that support a brand's messaging depend heavily on authenticity.

Theme 4: Challenges and opportunities identified during the implementation of social media campaigns

Social media always provides someone with a plethora of challenges and opportunities. Identifying and addressing them as early as possible is vital. **ID** acknowledges that negative feedback is inevitable, and not everyone will appreciate the content or brand collaborations. He advises not to be discouraged by negative comments and to focus on doing what feels right and highlights the resilience required to handle criticism and stay true to one's vision. **ID** states, *"Negative feedback is part of the game. Not everyone will like what you do, and that is okay. You must focus on doing what feels right to you and not letting negative comments bring you down."*

AA mentions that personalised codes created by brands allow the audience to get product discounts. He notes that getting enough engagement is essential for brands to continue extending contracts with athletes. This suggests that social media engagement and the ability to drive sales through personalised codes are key factors in securing future brand collaborations. **AA** explains, *"When brands create personalised codes for my followers, it not only benefits them but also helps me secure future collaborations. Brands want to see that their partnership with me generates sales and engagement."* He also mentions that he has not received any negative feedback so far, possibly due to his association with reputable brands. However, he acknowledges that handling negative feedback is not difficult, as people may

not always be well-informed or may deliberately badmouth brands. He emphasises the importance of researching before partnering with a brand and filtering out negative comments. **AA** states, *“I have not faced any negative feedback yet, but I know it is a possibility. It is important to do your research before partnering with a brand and be prepared to handle any negative comments. Not everyone will have accurate information, and some people may just want to criticise.”*

AG emphasises that longer deals allow for a more extensive data set to understand what works and what does not and provide opportunities to tweak brand campaigns. He states, *“Long-term associations are crucial because they give us a chance to really understand the brand and the athlete and make adjustments along the way.”* This highlights the significance of longevity in measuring the success of a sponsorship deal. Moreover, **AG** highlights the need to show value to clients, regardless of the duration or monetary value of the association. He believes that clients who see value in the collaboration are more likely to return for future partnerships. He states, *“It is not just about the money or the duration of the deal. It is about showing the client that their investment is worthwhile.”* This emphasises the importance of showcasing the benefits and impact of the collaboration to ensure continued partnerships.

AG also reveals themes related to the relevance of collaborations, breaking gender roles, preempting conflicts, and the importance of experimentation and flexibility in social media and sponsorship collaborations. One theme that emerges is the question of relevance in brand collaborations. **AG** argues that the audience’s opinion should not be the sole determinant of whether a collaboration makes sense. He gives examples of unexpected collaborations, such as a water purifier brand investing in cricket, to illustrate that brands have the right to explore and try something different. This suggests that relevance is subjective and can be influenced by factors beyond traditional expectations.

Another opportunity **AG** sees in this field is the changing dynamics of brand partnerships and the growing importance of social media in marketing strategies. He explains that brand collaborations can occur in two ways: either a brand reaches out to the athlete, or the marketing agency reaches out to various brands on behalf of the athlete. This highlights the proactive role of the agency in seeking out collaboration opportunities. **AG** also mentions the importance of influencer marketing and how athletes are seen as bonafide influencers due to their influence both on and off the field. This emphasises the evolving nature of brand collaborations and the increasing significance of social media in marketing strategies.

Furthermore, another notion that arises is the idea of breaking traditional gender roles in sponsorship collaborations. **AG** mentions that brands may choose to work with female athletes to challenge gender stereotypes or vice versa. He also notes that male athletes now endorse products traditionally associated with women's beauty. This highlights the evolving nature of sponsorship collaborations and the potential for brands to challenge societal norms through their partnerships. Along with this, he also mentions that there is no harm in trying something different if both the brand and the athlete are in sync with it. He gives an example of an ad featuring Rahul Dravid that went against his usual character, becoming a meme. This highlights the willingness to take risks and explore unconventional sponsorship-related approaches.

HM acknowledges that social media has undoubtedly transformed the landscape of sports marketing, providing athletes and brands with increased visibility. He emphasises the role of social media in building an athlete's personal brand through quality content, engagement with the audience, and utilising the latest features of social media platforms. This highlights the shift from traditional to modern media and the opportunities social media offers athletes and brands to reach a wider audience.

According to **ABR**, measuring the impact and effectiveness of brand endorsements on social media can be challenging due to metrics variations across platforms and the difficulty of attributing direct sales to endorsements. Fast&Up faces challenges in directly quantifying ROI but uses engagement metrics, such as likes, comments, and shares, as well as website traffic analysis and unique promo codes, to measure the impact and effectiveness of brand endorsements on social media. **ABR** said, *"To address this, we utilise a combination of engagement metrics (likes, comments, shares), website traffic analysis, and unique promo codes used during campaigns to gauge effectiveness."* **ABR** also says that while athlete endorsements enhance brand visibility, there is a potential risk tied to athletes' actions on social media. To mitigate this, Fast&Up establishes clear content guidelines and thoroughly vet athletes' online behaviour before endorsement. Regular communication and coaching help minimise any potential reputation risks to the brand. He said, *"To mitigate this, we establish clear content guidelines and conduct a thorough vetting of athletes' online behaviour before endorsement. Regular communication and coaching help minimise any potential reputation risks to our brand."*

Addressing the fourth objective, i.e., to identify the challenges as well as possibilities in evaluating the success of branding and sponsorship campaigns on social media platforms, for all stakeholders, a common theme that emerges from the provided content is the **challenges and opportunities** associated with measuring the effectiveness of branding and sponsorship campaigns on social media platforms for all stakeholders, including athletes and brands. The challenges include dealing with unfavourable criticism, particularly when it comes to preserving authenticity and giving practical answers to criticism. Additionally, because metrics differ across platforms, and it can be challenging to link sales to endorsements directly, evaluating social media campaigns' effectiveness and return on investment can be challenging. However, there are numerous opportunities as well, including the potential for long-term partnerships to collect significant data for campaign optimisation and proving value to clients. Also, there are opportunities for brands and athletes to improve their campaigns and reach a wider audience due to the shifting dynamics of brand partnerships, the development of social media in marketing, and the willingness to try new things.

Content Analysis

The following content analysis delves into Indian footballing athletes' social media posts, primarily focusing on evaluating the sentiment and engagement surrounding sponsorship and brand collaboration-related content. The goal is to determine how these endorsements affect athletes' personal brand image and marketability in India. Metrics such as likes and comments on these posts compared to the athletes' regular content and sentiment analysis will also be investigated. This analysis aims to provide valuable insights into the dynamic relationship between football athletes, their sponsors, and their online followers by scrutinising audience reactions and engagement patterns.

This content analysis will evaluate Indian football athletes' social media posts about sponsorships and brand collaborations. The sentiment of the comments, as well as track engagement metrics (likes, comments), will be analysed and compared to the athletes' regular posts. Data is collected over a set period of time, and sentiment analysis is performed using natural language processing tools. For social media content analysis, this study will look into the three most followed active Indian footballers on Instagram - Sunil Chhetri (6.6mil followers), Sahal Abdul Samad (1.3mil followers) and Gurpreet Singh Sandhu (372k followers). Each of these players' last five static posts, last five reels and last five brand/sponsorship collaboration posts were looked at to get the average number of likes,

average number of comments and the sentiment shown by their followers in the comments section. Google Sheets will be used to record these engagement metrics, the link to which can be found in Appendix (a).

The following table depicts the average number of likes and comments (approximate, rounded values) the said athletes get on their posts on Instagram:

ATHLETE	STATIC POST (LIKES & COMMENTS)	REELS (LIKES & COMMENTS)	COLLAB POST (LIKES & COMMENTS)
<i>Sunil Chhetri</i>	623k & 1.8k	940k & 6.1k	301k & 700
<i>Sahal Abdul Samad</i>	144k & 400	297k & 3.5k	89k & 200
<i>Gurpreet Singh Sandhu</i>	14k & 50	43k & 150	21k & 50

Table 1.0 - Average number of likes and comments (approximate, rounded values) the said athletes get on their posts on Instagram.

The difference between the engagement rate on a reel and a static post is evident, suggesting that the athletes and brands must use that feature while doing a campaign. Of the last five collaboration post that was looked at, both Chhetri and Sandhu had one static post among them (shown in Appendix (a)). The sentiments in the comments section are also largely positive for all three players, with fans expressing their love for the athletes. There were occasional banters in the comments section; however, those were related to the matches taking place as the football season has kicked off in India. Additionally, of the five latest posts that were looked at, the ones that got the most engagement were collaborative posts regarding eSports, conversations about life experiences, and showing support for other national sporting teams, among others. This suggests that collaborations with which the audience can relate more to are getting more engagement.

Conclusion

This research examined the symbiotic relationship between branding, sponsorship activation, and social media, specifically Instagram, in sports marketing and athlete endorsements in the context of Indian football. The study used a mixed-methods approach combining interviews and social media analysis to uncover stakeholders' strategies, challenges, and perceptions regarding leveraging Instagram for branding and sponsorships. Several key themes emerged from the thematic analysis of interviews with athletes, athlete representatives, and a brand representative.

Firstly, consistent, engaging social media content's role in building athletes' brand image and marketability was emphasised. Strategically using platforms like Instagram enables Indian footballers to shape their image, inspire audiences, and attract collaborations. However, maintaining authenticity across partnerships is vital.

Secondly, the importance of alignment between an athlete's values, social media presence, and potential brand associations was highlighted as a key criterion for the selection and success of endorsements. Careful vetting, transparent communication, and mutually beneficial terms facilitate meaningful collaborations aligned with the athlete's journey and brand identity.

Thirdly, authenticity in social media campaigns was underlined, with content creation requiring collaboration between stakeholders and emphasis on showcasing effort over flashy displays. Authenticity boosts audience engagement and brand reach, as evidenced by examples of successful campaigns.

Finally, measurement challenges, negative feedback, personalised engagement opportunities, and partnership evolution were identified as crucial considerations when evaluating and optimising branding activations on social media. Long-term associations, demonstrating ROI, and experimentation provide scope for growth despite limitations.

The social media analysis of posts by leading Indian footballers revealed higher engagement for sponsorships, allowing audience connections and indicating the need for relevant partnerships. Sentiment analysis showed overall positive responses to endorsements aligning with fans' support for the athletes.

These findings have important practical implications for leveraging social media and navigating brand collaborations in India's evolving sports marketing landscape. However, limitations around sample size, data availability, and constant platform changes must be acknowledged. The research makes valuable contributions by highlighting social media's potential for athlete branding and key alignment, authenticity, and agility strategies. It provides a foundation for further studies across sports contexts and regions. As virtual spaces transform fandom and consumership, scope exists for scholarship on optimising new technologies and metrics to evaluate endorsements.

In conclusion, by establishing the symbiotic relationship between athletes, brands, and audiences, this study underlines how strategic social media presence and partnerships can augment personal brand and marketability for sportspersons in India's dynamic digital environment. With considered application, these findings can benefit stakeholders in strengthening collaborations and engagement through authenticity, alignment, and consistent innovation.

Recommendations

Based on the findings and discussions, the following recommendations can be implemented to further the sports marketing industry in Indian football, focusing on the symbiotic relationship among branding, sponsorship and social media (the SMART framework for these recommendations can be found in Appendix (b)):

1. Athletes should consistently create engaging, authentic social media content that aligns with their brand identity and journey to build connections with fans. Telling unique stories can help strengthen their personal brand.
2. Carefully vetting potential brand partnerships is crucial to ensure alignment with the athlete's values, persona and target audience. Collaborations that authentically resonate with the athlete's journey tend to be most effective.

The first two recommendations align with what **ID** said, *as explained in the first theme of thematic analysis*, and also several other statements from *the second theme of thematic analysis* regarding the selection criteria of brands and athletes. It also supports Riitvis et al.

(2015), and Alexander's (2017) works, *as explained in the literature review*, which says that social media channels provide athletes with a versatile canvas to engage their audience through captivating storytelling, and consumers are more likely to feel emotionally connected to athletes when they hear honest stories about their journeys, difficulties, and how sponsored products fit into their lifestyles.

3. Brands must develop social media campaigns that integrate their messaging into the athlete's content seamlessly. Co-creating posts that showcase authentic endorsements is key. Experimenting with emerging technologies like live streams and NFTs can also boost engagement.

This aligns with **AG**'s statement of utilising the opportunity to experiment with campaigns and try something new in *the third theme of thematic analysis*. Also, *as previously mentioned in the literature review*, Fatma (2020) and Trautman (2022), respectively, say that the popularity of live streaming has also grown as a direct and genuine method for athletes to interact with their audience, and NFTs allow fans to have digital collectibles which will also give them a sense of ownership.

4. The parties involved in a potential or sure-shot collaboration must try to establish long-term partnerships to enable more prosperous optimisation over time.

This also aligns with what **AG** spoke about in the *third theme of the thematic analysis*. The longevity of a partnership helps in measuring the success of a sponsorship deal in a more effective way because of the larger extensive data set that will be available to scour through to understand what works and what does not in a partnership. This recommendation is also in line with **ABR**'s statement of being able to measure the ROI of a partnership using the engagement metrics in social media. A larger data set translates to a better understanding of the strategies' effectiveness.

The integration of these four recommendations with the Marketing Mix can also be found in Appendix (c).

Future Research Prospects

Given the limitations (as explained in the Methodology section), the following are a few areas among many others which, if researched in future, will give a better understanding of this industry:

- a) Conducting a similar study with a larger and more diverse sample of athletes, brands and sports to improve the generalisability of findings.
- b) Comparing endorsement marketing strategies across different social media platforms like Facebook, Twitter, YouTube etc., beyond just Instagram.
- c) Using more advanced social media analytics and machine learning to evaluate engagement and optimise branding campaigns.
- d) Assessing integrating new technologies like VR/AR and metaverse in sports marketing and endorsements.
- e) Analysis of legal and ethical implications surrounding the use of virtual influencers and avatars in sports promotions.

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Appendices

- (a) Social Media Data for Content Analysis -

https://docs.google.com/spreadsheets/d/1DwjCBL8AZzjqGs61PqQoA6IDHPYUPItol02I7uB3E_M/edit?usp=sharing

- (b) SMART framework of the four recommendations put together:

Specific (S): The first recommendation is specific in emphasising the importance of athletes consistently creating engaging and authentic social media content. To make it even more specific, the athletes could use content that has previously worked well for other campaigns as inspiration, such as sharing behind-the-scenes moments or personal challenges.

Measurable (M): The second suggestion emphasises the significance of carefully vetting brand partnerships. To make it measurable, athletes can use a set of criteria or a checklist to evaluate potential brand collaborations.

Achievable (A): The third recommendation is for brands to create social media campaigns that incorporate their messaging into the content of athletes. To achieve it, brands can work with athletes to produce engaging content or implement specific technologies like live streams and NFTs.

Relevant (R): The fourth recommendation is to establish long-term partnerships. It is relevant because such long-term collaborations align with the evolving landscape of social media and brand collaborations, which is especially important in the context of

this study.

Time-Bound (T): Each recommendation can include a time-bound component, such as athletes maintaining consistency in their social media content for a set period (e.g., once a week) to assess its impact or suggesting that brands implement new technologies (e.g., NFTs, live streams) in their next campaign.

(c) Integration of the four recommendations with Marketing Mix:

Content Creation (Product and Consumer-Centric Solution): Athletes should consistently create engaging, authentic social media content (Product) that aligns with their brand identity and journey. This addresses the Product component of the marketing mix by ensuring that the content is of high quality and resonates with the target audience. It also caters to the Consumer Solution (one of the 4Cs) by providing content that genuinely addresses the audience's needs and desires and connecting with and delivering value to fans.

Brand Partnerships (Product, Price and Communication): It is critical to carefully vet brand partnerships (Product) to ensure alignment with the athlete's principles and target audience. This addresses the "Product" and "Price" elements, ensuring the collaboration resonates with the audience. In this context, "price" could represent the athlete's and audience's perceived value of the brand partnership. This alignment ensures that the product (collaboration) is not only of high quality but also valuable to both the athlete and the consumers. This alignment with consumer interests and values is closely related to the "Communication" element, which ensures that communication about the collaboration reaches and engages the audience.

Social Media Campaigns (Promotion and Convenience): Brands must create social media campaigns (Promotion) that integrate their messaging seamlessly into the athlete's content. Co-creating genuine endorsements aligns with the marketing mix's Promotion component. Experimenting with new technologies such as live streams and NFTs can increase engagement by adding an element of Convenience (one of the 4Cs), making it easier and more convenient for the audience to interact with the content via these innovative technologies.

Long-term Partnerships (Place and Customer Cost): Long-term partnerships (Place) between the involved parties are critical for more prosperous optimization over time. This addresses Place within the marketing mix by focusing on collaboration distribution and placement (the idea here is that long-term partnerships

is not directly related to product distribution or placement (which is what “Place” traditionally represents). It also relates to Customer Cost (one of the 4Cs) by providing consistency and predictability, which lowers the audience’s cost (in terms of time and effort) in locating new collaborations and understanding the athlete’s brand image over time.

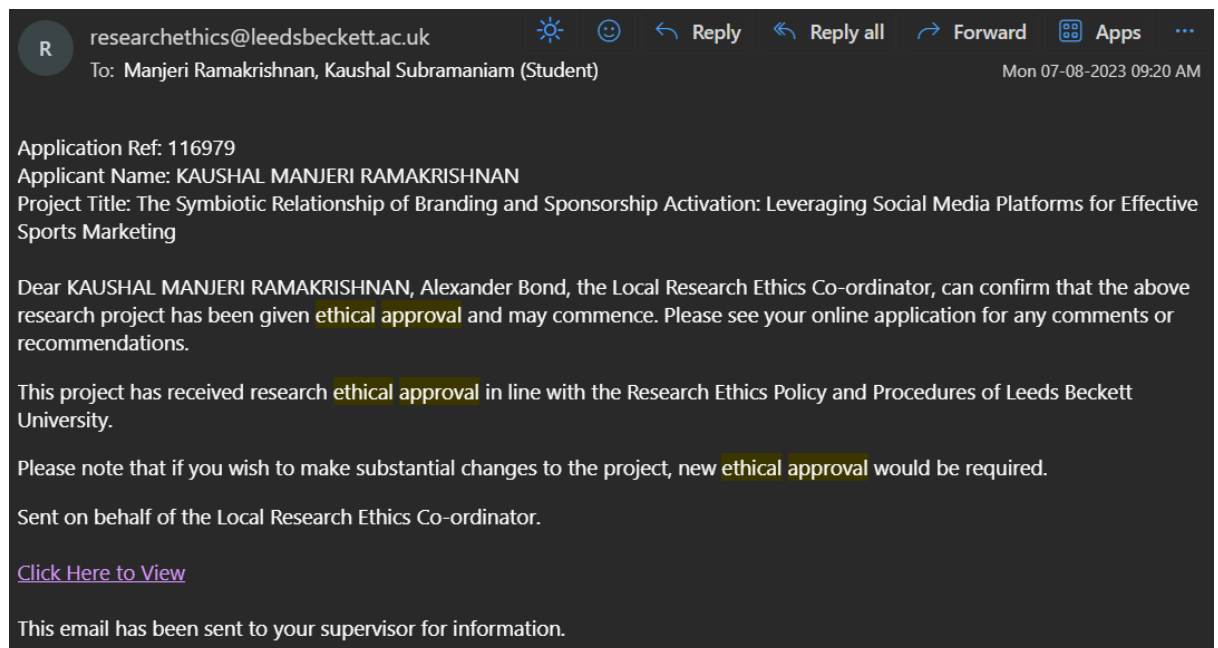
(d) Information Sheet -

https://docs.google.com/document/d/16nY-B_FlilxdEPy0B17j54kxnfhVcz5SRbHm-2a_Vo0/edit?usp=sharing

(e) Consent Form -

<https://docs.google.com/document/d/188Vtoh39HX2Knqb0lUbVHQab0Q4M3isfr-bxO1dl0BY/edit?usp=sharing>

(f) Ethics Form -



(g) Interview Guide (Questions) -

https://docs.google.com/document/d/1WAGx_f3Q5bpjlvunr25HvhxEuRFvQIl8Rjge-mWXFlo/edit?usp=sharing